SKY TECH ACADEMY
ROPE ACCESS TRAINING CENTER

OILFIELD | INDUSTRY | SAFETY | EXPERTISE

ROPE ACCESS LEVEL 1
CANDIDATE TRAINING BINDER

SPRAT	IRATA
Level 1 Technician	Level 1 Technician

Houston, Texas | 2026

Section 1 — Safe System of Work

Both SPRAT and IRATA maintain their own training, assessment, and competency requirements for each certification level. While the two systems are very similar in philosophy and work practices, there are differences in specific techniques, maneuver requirements, terminology, and assessment criteria.

This section explains the rope access maneuvers, identifies which certification system they apply to, and clarifies the competency level required within each system.

1.1 Governing Documents

SPRAT — Governing Documents	IRATA — Governing Documents
✓ Safe Practices for Rope Access Work ✓ Certification Requirements for Rope Access Work	✓ International Code of Practice (ICOP) ✓ Training, Assessment & Certification Scheme (TACS) ✓ Audited Member company procedures

1.2 Safe System — Candidate Knowledge Requirements

SPRAT Requirements	IRATA Requirements
• Demonstrate understanding of duties and responsibilities as written in Safe Practices • Working understanding of the employer's rope access program, all applicable policies and procedures • Demonstrate awareness of appropriate supervision on the worksite • Understand the skills and knowledge required by Certification Requirements and Safe Practices for Rope Access Work	• Show awareness of the three governing elements and the role of each in forming a safe system of work • Awareness of ICOP's requirement that all rope access work is carried out within the management framework of an audited member company • Awareness of ICOP's requirement for supervision by a Level 3 rope access safety supervisor • Awareness of technician competence levels, role of logbooks, and requirements for revalidation and level progression

📌 **Sky Tech Academy:** *All candidates must familiarize themselves with the governing documents of their certification scheme before attending training. Copies are available from your instructor.*

1.3 Jurisdictional Requirements

All candidates must demonstrate an understanding of jurisdictional regulations applicable to their workplace — in the USA: OSHA 29 CFR 1910 (General Industry) and 29 CFR 1926 (Construction), plus ANSI Z359 fall protection standards.

SPRAT — Jurisdictional	IRATA — Jurisdictional
• Level III: sufficient knowledge of current regulations that apply, directly or indirectly, to rope access and working at height, to ensure compliance by employees being supervised	• Level 3: demonstrate familiarity with the legal framework of their operating country, including any regulations relevant to rope access activities

1.4 Risk Assessment

Risk assessment is the process of identifying hazards and evaluating potential risks. Level 1 candidates must understand basic hazard identification principles and emergency procedures. Comprehensive risk assessment training applies at Levels 2 and 3.

SPRAT — Risk Assessment	IRATA — Risk Assessment
• Level I: Understand employer's safety management program, relevant policies, work permits, work zones, and job safety analysis; be aware of site hazards and emergency procedures • Level II: Understand employer's safety management program, relevant policies, work permits, and work zones/JSA • Level III: Carry out the employer's safety management program including writing a job safety analysis	• All candidates: show awareness of the role of risk assessment within the process of planning and managing rope access activities • Level 3: demonstrate understanding of the risk assessment process and identify hazards — falls from height, weather, falling tools, unusual loads, rope stretch, sharp edges, anchor failure, equipment failure, emergency evacuation, and rescue provision

1.5 Selection of Access Method

Candidates should be able to identify the most appropriate method of working at height based upon a pre-job hazard analysis. Rope access is not always the most suitable option.

SPRAT	IRATA
• Level III: sufficient knowledge of current regulations; specify appropriate rope access equipment,	• All candidates: confirm that rope access is a suitable method for the task

SPRAT	IRATA
systems, and components; supervise their installation, use, and inspection	• Level 3: assess suitability of rope access for a variety of scenarios; identify situations where MEWPs, work restraint, or fall arrest systems would be more appropriate

1.6 Method Statement

A method statement is a plan for effectively and safely conducting the assigned work. Based upon the safe system of work and the risk assessment, it states the sequence of procedures needed to complete work and must incorporate a rescue plan.

⚠ **All Candidates:** *All candidates shall show an understanding of the role of the method statement and the importance of following it at all times.*

1.7 Exclusion Zones

Exclusion zones are established as protection from falling objects and to prevent access to areas where falls from height could occur. All candidates shall demonstrate an awareness of the types of exclusion zones and the need to create and maintain them.

SPRAT — Zone Definitions	IRATA — Zone Requirements
• Access Zone — the area where people are at risk of falling (on-rope or near a working edge); requires protective measures: warnings, signs, barriers, or safety lines • Hazard Zone — any area where a person may be at risk as a result of the work being performed	• Level 2 & 3: demonstrate understanding of the process and requirements for creating and maintaining exclusion zones, including permit to work systems, size requirements, types of barriers, and policing • Four IRATA exclusion zones: anchor area, working edge, intermediate level, and bottom level

1.8 Planning for Emergencies

All method statements for rope access operations should incorporate a plan for emergencies, including evacuation of the worksite and rescue of operatives. All candidates shall demonstrate awareness of their role in these plans, including basic first aid and suspension trauma awareness.

SPRAT	IRATA
• Level II: working knowledge of rope access rescue procedures and emergency response, including harness-induced suspension trauma and the importance of prompt and safe rescue • Level III: strong understanding of rescue procedures, emergency planning, and rescue management; organize, supervise, and manage team rescue scenarios safely and effectively	• Level 3: capable of preparing and implementing both evacuation and rescue plans

Section 2 — Equipment Use & Selection

Equipment must be selected based on suitability for the intended purpose, compatibility with other system components, compliance with applicable regulations and standards, and the manufacturer's recommendations.

2.1 Care, Use & Maintenance

Rope access equipment is exposed to wear and tear, abrasion, extreme temperatures, UV exposure, chemical contamination, and misuse. All equipment must be inspected before use and undergo regular formal inspections. Equipment should be individually identifiable to ensure proper inspection and maintenance records are maintained.

SPRAT — Equipment Requirements	IRATA — Equipment Requirements
• Level I: proper use, inspection, and care of all equipment required for technical skills; understand the company's equipment management program • Level II: same as Level I — equipment management program understanding • Level III: thorough understanding of proper use, inspection, and care of all worksite equipment; manage and carry out the employer's equipment management program	• All candidates: demonstrate functional, visual, and tactile pre-use checks of all personal equipment • Levels 2 & 3: functional, visual, and tactile pre-use checks of all ropes and rigging • Level 3: demonstrate appropriate marking and storage procedures; complete inspection reports on damaged equipment; understand the limits of competence in carrying out detailed inspections

Section 3 — Anchor Systems

3.1 Anchor Selection

Rope access operations rely on a variety of anchors, including structural beams, eye-bolts, and temporary ground anchors. Technicians responsible for selecting anchors must ensure they are competent, properly trained, and authorized to perform anchor assessment and selection in accordance with applicable standards.

Anchor Selection	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		
Demonstrate awareness of the minimum strength requirements for rope access anchors	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Capable of inspecting and verifying the integrity of more complex anchors built in the field by Level II/III candidates		✓	✓			
Capable of selecting suitable structural elements to be used as rope access anchors		✓	✓		✓	✓

3.2 Basic Anchor Systems

At a minimum, a basic anchor system consists of a two-rope system, each with its own anchor connection.

Basic Anchor Systems	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		
Demonstrate rigging of a basic anchor for a two-rope system around a structural member	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Demonstrate rigging of a basic anchor for a two-rope system around a structural member while working at height		✓	✓		✓	✓

3.3 Load Sharing Anchors

Used when rigging ropes between two separate structural elements. The included angle between anchor legs must never exceed 120°. A maximum angle of 90° is recommended.

Load Sharing Anchors	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		
Demonstrate rigging of a small load sharing anchor system — anchors less than 1 meter (3.28 ft) apart	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Load Sharing Anchors	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Demonstrate rigging of a wide load sharing anchor system — anchors more than 1 meter apart (SPRAT > 2m; IRATA performed at height)		✓	✓		✓	✓
Show awareness of angle loading issues and potential swings associated with wide load sharing anchor systems	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Section 4 — Rope Access Maneuvers

The skill matrix for each maneuver shows which certification level requires that skill. A filled cell with ✓ indicates the skill is required at that level for that scheme. An empty cell indicates the skill is not required at that level.

4.1 Back-up Devices

Although rarely used for arresting a fall, back-up devices are a critical element of a safe work system. Correct use, maintenance, and inspection will be monitored throughout all training and certification activities.

Back-up Devices	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		
Demonstrate correct use of a back-up device throughout training in accordance with industry best practice, Sky Tech Academy risk assessment, and manufacturer's instructions	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

4.2 Descent

The controlled descent is a core rope access technique. Technicians must control rate of descent and stop as needed. Additional friction is required when technician weight exceeds 100 kg (225 lbs) or during a rescue.

Descent	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		
Demonstrate attaching and function testing a descending device; demonstrate safe control of the standing/tail rope while descending; demonstrate stopping and locking the device	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Demonstrate ascending a rope at least 2 meters (6.56 ft) with a descent device	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

4.3 Ascent

Climbing a rope is a core rope access technique. Technicians must demonstrate the alternating use of two ascending devices.

Ascent	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		

Ascent	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Demonstrate attaching and function testing ascending devices; demonstrate ascending a rope using ascending devices	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Demonstrate descending a rope at least 2 meters (6.56 ft) with an ascent device	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

4.4 Change-Over

Changing from descent mode to ascent mode (or vice-versa) are core rope access techniques required at all levels.

Change-Over	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	SPRAT			IRATA		
Demonstrate changing from ascent to descent mode and vice-versa	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

4.5 Deviations

Deviations allow the re-direction of ropes around obstructions, to allow for repositioning and to avoid hazards such as abrasions and hot surfaces. Candidates must avoid the potential for out of control swings.

Deviations	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	SPRAT			IRATA		
Demonstrate passing a single anchor deviation (less than 20° from anchors) in ascent and descent mode	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Demonstrate passing a double anchor deviation (more than 20° from anchors) in ascent and descent mode				✓	✓	✓

4.6 Rope to Rope Transfer

Allows near horizontal movement. Candidates must avoid potential out of control swings through the use of four points of attachment when necessary. Rope angles must be kept below 120°.

Rope to Rope Transfer	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	SPRAT			IRATA		
Demonstrate transferring from one rope to another at least 2 meters (6.56 ft) apart	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

4.7 Re-belay (Re-anchor)

A re-belay is a secondary set of anchors installed at any distance below the primary anchors. Candidates must avoid potential out of control swings through the use of four points of attachment when necessary.

Re-belay	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		
Demonstrate passing a re-belay less than 1.5 meters (5 ft) horizontally from the primary anchor	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Demonstrate passing a re-belay more than 2 meters (6.5 ft) horizontally from the primary anchor		✓	✓			

4.8 Passing Mid-Rope Obstructions

Knots are placed mid rope to isolate minor damaged sections, or to join two ropes. Candidates shall not use a knot used to isolate a damaged section of rope as a connection point.

Passing Mid-Rope Obstructions	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		
Demonstrate passing mid-rope knots in both ascent and descent modes	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Demonstrate the ability to identify, isolate, and pass minor damage in a rope by tying the appropriate knot						✓

4.9 Negotiate Edge

Edges such as roofs, platforms, and parapet walls present additional hazards. Fall restraint methods must be used around unprotected edges. Appropriate edge protection must be installed. Impact loads must be avoided.

Negotiate Edge	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		
Demonstrate passing a top edge obstruction in ascent and descent modes	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

4.10 Rope Protection

Rope protectors guard against abrasion hazards. Separate protectors should be used for each rope. The protection chosen should be appropriate to the specific hazard encountered.

Rope Protection	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		
Demonstrate attaching wrap-around style rope protection while on rope — separate protection for each rope is preferred	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Demonstrate passing and replacing mid-rope protection in ascent or descent mode	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

4.11 Fall Factors

The fall factor is a numerical representation of the severity of a fall — calculated by dividing the length of fall by the length of rope in the system. Target: FF = 0 or as close as possible at all times.

Fall Factors	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		
Demonstrate understanding of fall factor and explain the method for calculating a fall factor	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

4.12 Pull Through System

A pull through system allows ropes to be installed and retrieved remotely. Care must be taken to utilize the correct ropes and not the retrieval side. The candidate should identify the retrieval side to avoid mistakes.

Pull Through System	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		
Demonstrate a method to retrieve ropes from a structural anchor after descent		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Section 5 — Knots

Tying knots is a core element in working at height. Knots provide additional shock absorbing capacity when rigging anchor systems, and are commonly used in lanyard attachments, securing and joining ropes, and to prevent descending off of ropes.

> ⚠ **Assessment Standard:** *Candidates shall demonstrate the tying, dressing, and setting of all required knots and have an awareness of their strengths, applications, and limitations.*

Category	Knot Type(s)	SPRAT			IRATA		
		L1	L2	L3	L1	L2	L3
End Knot	Figure 8 / Double Fig 8 / Figure 9 on a Bight	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Mid Knot	Alpine Butterfly	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Stop Knot	Barrel Knot	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Join Knot	Figure-Eight Join		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Friction Hitch	Prusik (Three-wrap)		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Load Releasing	Italian (Munter) Hitch		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Choking	Sling Choke		✓	✓		✓	✓

Section 6 — Rigging, Lowering & Rescue Systems

6.1 Lowering Systems

In situations where top anchors are easily accessible and a clear vertical descent is available, rescue operations can be effectively managed using a pre-rigged releasable lowering system. This allows the rescuer to safely lower a suspended casualty without complex rope transfer procedures.

Lowering Systems	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		
Demonstrate rigging and operating a lowering system	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Demonstrate the operation and safe use of a simple pre-rigged rescue system designed for an unimpeded vertical lower	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

6.2 Cross Haul

A cross haul is used to move a load through a 3-dimensional course. All systems should utilize a back-up system. This is generally a team exercise.

Cross Haul	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		
Demonstrate a cross haul of a load between two points		✓	✓		✓	✓

6.3 Hauling & Lowering Through Knots

Candidates must safely raise and lower a casualty or load when knots are present in both main and backup lines. The casualty or load must be suspended at least 2 m below the knots; the knots must be at least 2 m below the anchorage system.

Hauling and Lowering Through Knots	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		
Raising and lowering with knots in the system — from a suspended position or platform			✓			✓

6.4 Tensioned Lines

Ropes tensioned between two sets of anchors facilitate near horizontal or diagonal movement. Additional working and safety lines are required to control movement. Ropes should be rigged with as little tension as possible. Back-up safety management is critical.

Tensioned Lines	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		
Demonstrate rigging and use of a tensioned rope system		✓	✓		✓	✓

6.5 Climbing Techniques

Climbing Techniques	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		
Horizontal aid climbing — using a series of fixed or movable anchors (maintain 2 independent points of attachment at all times; fall factor < 1)	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Vertical aid climbing — progressing primarily in suspension in an upward direction (2 independent points at all times; fall factor < 1)		✓	✓		✓	✓
Climbing with fall arrest equipment — demonstrate vertical climb using pre-installed temporary fall arrest system	✓	✓	✓			
Demonstrate climbing using a shock absorbing Y-lanyard system, maintaining appropriate attachment at all times				✓	✓	✓

Section 7 — Rescue Operations

This section defines the requirements for conducting safe and efficient rescue operations during rope access activities, in accordance with Sky Tech Academy procedures and industry best practices (SPRAT / IRATA).

7.1 General Rescue Principles

Rescue Hierarchy

1. Pre-rigged rescue system (primary preferred method)
2. Assisted rescue using additional equipment
3. Rescue using casualty's equipment

Scene Assessment — Before Initiating Any Rescue

- Conduct a dynamic risk assessment: environmental hazards, structural integrity, equipment condition
- Confirm anchor suitability and system stability
- Identify potential risks to rescuer(s), casualty, and third parties

Casualty Management

- Conscious casualties: instruct to move lower extremities regularly to maintain circulation and reduce suspension intolerance risk
- Casualty handling must be controlled, smooth, and minimized to avoid further injury
- If required, use a work seat or reposition casualty to improve comfort and circulation

7.2 Rescue Maneuvers Matrix

Rescue Operations	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Skill / Competency	**SPRAT**			**IRATA**		
Rescue from descent mode — adjacent set of ropes; casualty approached from above or below (SPRAT Level I may use adjacent or casualty's ropes)	✓	✓	✓		✓	✓
Rescue from descent mode — from casualty's set of ropes; casualty approached from above or below				✓	✓	✓
Rescue from ascent mode — from casualty's set of ropes or a separate set of ropes		✓	✓		✓	✓
Level 1 Rescue Scenario (SPRAT only): pick-off from ascent mode → approach from adjacent ropes → changeover to descent → rescue from descent	✓					
Passing a single anchor deviation with a casualty			✓		✓	✓

Rescue Operations	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3
Passing a double anchor deviation with a casualty						✓
Rope to rope transfer with a casualty — ropes rigged at least 3 meters (9.84 ft) apart		✓	✓		✓	✓
Passing a small re-belay with a casualty — re-anchors not offset more than 1.5 meters (5 ft)		✓	✓		✓	✓
Mid-rope transfer rescue — casualty suspended at any point in a wide rope to rope transfer or re-belay			✓			✓
Passing mid-rope knots with a casualty		✓	✓		✓	✓
Rescue from an aid climb — casualty suspended by work-positioning lanyards		✓	✓		✓	✓
Rescue from an aid climb — casualty on a short connection, no higher anchors (IRATA Level 3 only)						✓
Passing a large re-belay with a casualty			✓			✓

Section 8 — Level 1 Technician Requirements Summary

Rope access training at Level 1 is structured around two essential components: theoretical knowledge and practical demonstration. Theoretical understanding alone is not sufficient — it must be supported by the ability to apply these concepts in real situations.

8.1 Level 1 Assessment Checklist

☐	Skill / Requirement	Applies To
☐	Assessment Requirements — Written theory exam and affidavit completion	**SPRAT & IRATA**
☐	Back-up Device Handling — Correct use demonstrated throughout all activities	**SPRAT & IRATA**
☐	Ascender — Ascent and descent using ascending devices	**SPRAT & IRATA**
☐	Descender — Ascent, descent, and lock-off	**SPRAT & IRATA**
☐	Change-overs — Ascent to descent and vice-versa	**SPRAT & IRATA**
☐	Use of the Work Seat (comfort seat)	**IRATA only**
☐	Passing Knots — Isolate damaged ropes and pass mid-rope knots	**SPRAT & IRATA**
☐	Rope to Rope Transfers	**SPRAT & IRATA**
☐	Deviations — Single (SPRAT); Single & Double (IRATA)	**SPRAT & IRATA**
☐	Re-Belays — Small < 1.5m (IRATA); Large > 2m (SPRAT)	**SPRAT & IRATA**
☐	Negotiate Edge and Install Edge Protection	**SPRAT & IRATA**
☐	Climbing with Shock Absorbing Lanyards	**IRATA only**
☐	Anchorage Systems — Simple structural and load sharing < 1 meter	**SPRAT & IRATA**
☐	Hauling & Lowering Systems	**SPRAT & IRATA**
☐	Roles and Responsibilities — Knowledge of duties at Level 1	**SPRAT & IRATA**
☐	Equipment Use and Inspection — Pre-use functional, visual, and tactile checks	**SPRAT & IRATA**
☐	Job Safety — JSA, work zones, hazard identification, emergency procedures	**SPRAT & IRATA**
☐	Pick-off Rescue from Descent — Rescue of incapacitated casualty	**IRATA only**
☐	Level 1 Rescue Scenario — Combined pick-off from ascent + rescue from descent	**SPRAT only**
☐	Horizontal Aid Climbing — Fixed or movable anchors	**SPRAT & IRATA**
☐	Rope and Sling Protection	**SPRAT & IRATA**

8.2 Required Knots — Level 1

Category	Knot Type(s)	SPRAT			IRATA		
		L1	L2	L3	L1	L2	L3
End Knot	Figure 8 / Double Fig 8 / Figure 9 on a Bight	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Mid Knot	Alpine Butterfly	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Stop Knot	Barrel Knot	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Join Knot	Figure-Eight Join		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Friction Hitch	Prusik (Three-wrap)		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Load Releasing	Italian (Munter) Hitch		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Choking	Sling Choke		✓	✓		✓	✓

8.3 SPRAT Level 1 Rescue Scenario

SPRAT requires Level 1 candidates to perform a combined rescue scenario during assessment. The candidate shall perform the following as one combined exercise:

4. Approach a casualty who is in ascending equipment — from an adjacent set of ropes
5. Install the casualty's descender directly under the casualty's chest ascender on the working line
6. Perform a pick-off from ascent mode and lower the casualty onto the casualty's descender
7. Perform a rescue from descent

> 📌 **IRATA:** *IRATA requires the pick-off from descent and rescue from ascent as two separate exercises. Sky Tech Academy trains both methods independently so candidates are prepared for either assessment scheme.*

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